what of Rishabh Pant, who refused plaster for his broken toe till the Old Trafford Test was over, so that he would not be found wanting while batting to save the match.

Former Indian captain Sunil Gavaskar, when asked whether this Indian team had displayed a certain character as the series rolled on, told INDIA TODAY, "Yes, you could certainly see that, with the way they fought back from difficult situations." He reserved special praise for skipper Gill: "The captain was the one that never gave up. He never gave his wicket away even after he got a 100, even after he got a double hundred, even after he got 250. And that is the spirit with which this team played. Hanging in there irrespective of the situation...that's how in tough situations they found that extra piece of energy that took them over the line."

A LEADER EMERGES

For new captain Gill, this was a baptism by fire. And he came through with flying colours. Although there were errors—the under-bowling of Washington Sundar at Old Trafford, the strangely defensive fields at Headingley, the revolving door at No.3 between Sai Sudharsan and Karun Nair, and the inexplicable dropping of Prasidh Krishna for an untested Anshul Kamboj (again at Old Trafford)—the net takeaways were positive. The 25-year-old came through with his reputation much enhanced.

Indian batsmen, powered by 12 centuries, plundered 3,807 runs against England—the most ever scored by a team in a five-match Test series

When you appoint your best batter captain, there is always the chance of losing him as a run-scorer. Cricketing history is littered with such casualties. But Gill, with 754 runs in the series, has put those concerns to rest emphatically. His purple patch from the IPL, where he was among the top five scorers and also captain of the Gujarat Ti-



YASHASVI JAISWAL 23

Left-handed batsman

Yashasvi Jaiswal plays cricket with fearless exuberance. A prodigy forged on the unforgiving maidans of Mumbai, in England, he faced his first true test against quality seam bowling with the Dukes ball—and emerged with distinction. He amassed 411 runs at an average of 41.10, with two centuries and two half-centuries. His 101 at Leeds came after weathering a hostile opening burst. His second, a measured, second innings 118 at The Oval during the series decider, showcased his growing maturity. It was a spring-loaded innings of grit. Occasionally undone by early swing, he never retreated into a shell. The touch of rawness in his technique is counterbalanced by natural timing and an electric sense of purpose. A luminous career awaits him.

—Amitabh Srivastava

Test Matches: 24
Runs: 2,209
Avg: 50.20
Highest score 214*